1. Introduction to American Literature

American literature, the body of written works produced in the English language in the United States. Like other national literatures, American literature was shaped by the history of the country that produced it. For almost a century and a half, America was merely a group of colonies scattered along the eastern seaboard of the North American continent—colonies from which a few hardy souls tentatively ventured westward. After a successful rebellion against the motherland, America became the United States, a nation.

2. American Literary Periods

2.1. The Colonial Period (1600s -1776)

The history of American literature begins in the early 1600s. The earliest writers were Englishmen describing the English exploration and colonization of the New World (America). Thomas Hariot's *Briefe and True Report of the New-Found Land of Virginia* (1588) was only the first of many such works. Captain John Smith helped found Jamestown, the first English Colony in America. He wrote histories based on his adventures, such as *True Relation of Virginia* (1608) and *Description of New England* (1616) which were "advertisements" to persuade the reader to settle in the New World. Smith's *General Historie of Virginia, New England and the Summer Isles* (1624) contains the story of his rescue by a beautiful Indian princess, Pocahontas.

Religion is prominent in colonial American literature and can be found mostly in Puritan writings. The Puritans wrote about the religious foundations of many of their settlements, especially the exodus from Britain, and employed the constant theme that God should be worshiped. *Of Plymouth Plantation (*written between 1630 and 1651) by William Bradford, is the most interesting work of the Puritan histories. It describes the Puritans' difficult relations with the Indians. It also describes their difficulties during the first winter, when half of the small colony died. This history is told in plain style (speech or writing that is simple, direct, and straightforward).

John Winthrop, was first the governor of Massachusetts Bay Colony and one of the most prominent writers of Puritan histories. The most important work of Winthrop is his journal, *The History of New England* (1630-1649). The journal (which is also in the plain style) begins with his recording of the journey from England to America, but as time went on

it also served as a way of documenting civic and social details for the colony. His observations included daily occurrences of early New England life, as well as a look into his political standings and religious ideologies.

Richard Mather (1596-1669), the founder of his family in America, was admired as a typical strong Puritan minister and preacher. His son, Increase Mather (1639-1723) was a leader of the New England theocracy. He was also a minister at North Church in Boston, the most powerful church in New England. In his best-known book, *Remarkable Providences* (1684), Increase Mather describes the general atmosphere of Salem, Massachusetts as witchcraft dominated the Puritans' beliefs. Increase's son, Cotton Mather (1663-1728), was the most famous of the family. He wrote more than 450 works. Whenever something happened to him in his life, Cotton Mather wrote a religious book. For example, he wrote *The Best Way of Living, Which is to Die Daily* when his little daughter died.

2.2. The Revolutionary and Early National Period (1776-1830)

The most memorable writing in eighteenth-century America was done by the founding fathers, the men who led the Revolution of 1775-1783 and who wrote the Constitution of 1789. None of them were writers of fiction. Rather, they were practical philosophers, and their typical product was the **pamphlet** (short book of a few pages)**.** They admired and were active in the European "Age of Reason" or Enlightenment. Unlike the Puritans, who saw man as a sinful nature, the Enlightenment thinkers believed that man could improve himself.

Benjamin Franklin's *Autobiography (1771-1784),* described his life. Parts of it were published as early as 1791 (in French), although all four parts were not published together in English until 1868. According to a friend of Franklin's, one the goals of the autobiography was to provide a model by which others could better their lives and, in fact, it stands as one of the first examples of a "self-help" book. It is also considered important in the development of the autobiography genre.

The greatest pamphlet-writer of the American Revolution, Thomas Pain, wrote *Common Sense* (1776), the most historically important pamphlet in American history. Its clear thinking and exciting language quickly united American feelings against England. Pain wrote in this pamphlet: "There is something absurd in supposing a continent (America) to be perpetually controlled by an Island (Britain). Between 1776 and 1783, Thomass pain could write a series of thirteen pamphlets entitled *The Crisis*.

A different group of authors, however, became leaders in the new period, Thomas Jefferson and the talented writers of the Federalist papers, a series of 85 essays published in 1787 and 1788 urging the virtues of the proposed new constitution. They were written by Alexander Hamilton, James Madison, and John Jay.

Thomas Jefferson was an influential political writer during and after the war. He wrote *Declaration of Independence*, the most important document in the political history of the United States. The Declaration was stated in a clear and logical style based on Jefferson's ideas of Enlightenment.

The **Early National Period** of American Literature saw the beginnings of literature that could be truly identified as "American". The writers of this new American literature wrote in the English style, but the settings, themes, and characters were authentically American. In addition, poets of this time wrote poetry that was relatively independent of English precursors. Three of the most recognized writers of this time are Washington Irving, James Fenimore Cooper, and Edgar Allan Poe.[4] Washington Irving published the collection of short stories and essays, *The Sketch Book of Geoffrey Crayon, Gent*. in 1819–20. It included "The Legend of Sleepy Hollow" and "Rip Van Winkle," two of the earliest American short stories.

Sources

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